

WEIRDEST HARDWARE PRODUCT EVER?

Google's new camera decides what to photograph, based on AI algorithms • LEVEL B

By David Pogue | *Scientific American*, May 2018



Google Clips: a tiny, clip-on AI camera designed to photograph family moments automatically — without anyone needing to press a button.

What Is the Google Clips Camera?

Google's Clips camera is a tiny device, roughly the size of two small crackers. You can set it down anywhere or clip it to any surface. Once you turn it on, you do not need to press a button or use a timer — the camera itself decides when to take a picture, based on Google's artificial intelligence **algorithms**. The camera's heart is in the right place: it tries to solve a real problem for its target audience, which is parents of young children or pets.

The problem it is trying to fix is a familiar one. If you are a parent, you are probably rarely in any of your own photographs, because you are always the one holding the camera. On top of that, young children often stop doing whatever cute thing they were doing the moment you pull out your phone — they get **distracted** by it or become **self-conscious**. The Clips camera avoids this problem because it is small and **unobtrusive**: it simply sits there quietly without drawing anyone's attention, and captures moments naturally, without interruption.

How Does the AI Actually Work?

It is important to understand that the AI in the Clips camera is not **organic** — it does not think for itself. It has been **programmed** by engineers who are informed by photography experts. In other words, the AI does not ultimately decide what makes a good picture; its programmers do. Some of its decision-making is fairly obvious: it looks for scenes of activity, it favours familiar subjects — people whose faces it sees most often — and it avoids capturing images when something is blocking the lens. It prefers good lighting and takes its best shots from around three to

eight feet away.

But the camera's AI also has more complex rules. It is designed to wait for happy facial expressions and tends not to photograph anyone who looks sad, angry, sleepy, bored, or upset. This rule, while well-intentioned, actually rules out a large amount of potentially interesting photography. A young child's life is full of small, **tragicomic** moments that might be worth recording — even if they involve brief tears. His ice cream fell on the floor. A puppy licked her face too enthusiastically. A well-meaning clown frightened him. These are precisely the kinds of authentic memories that make a family photo collection feel real and human.

Google is aware of this limitation and has reportedly planned to add a new **preference** setting — not a checkbox called 'Include Misery', but an option that makes the camera watch for *changes* in facial expression, rather than only capturing smiles. In the meantime, the camera's preference for joyful moments tends to **exaggerate** the two happiness filters we already apply to our own lives.

■ WHAT THE AI CAPTURES

- Familiar faces it recognises from previous photos.
- Active, lively scenes with movement and energy.
- Happy or smiling facial expressions.
- Well-lit subjects at a distance of 3–8 feet.
- Moments when nothing is blocking the lens.

■ WHAT THE AI AVOIDS

- Sad, angry, sleepy, or bored facial expressions.
- Anything blocking the lens, such as fingers or hands.
- Dark or poorly lit scenes.
- **Tragicomic** moments — tears, accidents, or surprises.
- Unfamiliar faces that the **algorithm** does not recognise.

How We Already Edit Our Own Lives

In reality, we already **curate** our memories long before any AI gets involved. We do this first by choosing what to photograph at all — most people, most of the time, record only the high points: celebrations, holidays, achievements. Your photo collection probably contains very few pictures of arguments, disappointments, or difficult days. We then curate a second time by choosing which photos to post online. At this point, we are not just editing our memories for ourselves — we are consciously constructing a version of our lives for an audience. We become, in effect, **brand ambassadors** for our own supposedly perfect existence.

Research has shown that this constant stream of carefully selected, happy content can affect people who view it. Studies have found that seeing only the positive highlights of other people's lives on social media can lead to what researchers call 'Facebook envy' — a feeling that everyone else's life is more exciting, more successful, and more joyful than your own. The irony, of course, is that those people are doing exactly the same thing you are: showing only the best version of themselves, while keeping the messier reality private.

"We further curate our recordings by choosing which to post online. At this point, we don't just risk deceiving ourselves about the overall happiness balance in our lives; we're explicitly trying to paint a picture of a wonderful life for our followers."

— David Pogue, *Scientific American*

1.4B

photos uploaded to Facebook every day

90%

of people admit to editing photos before
posting

32%

of teens report feeling bad after viewing social
media

Beyond Clips: AI, Deepfakes, and the Question of Authenticity

The Google Clips camera raises a question that goes far beyond one quirky gadget: as AI becomes increasingly capable of deciding what we see, capture, and share, what happens to **authenticity**? The Clips camera simply filters out unhappy moments. But today's more advanced AI tools can do something far more significant — they can generate images and videos of things that never happened at all.

These are known as deepfakes — **synthetic** media created by AI that can realistically **manipulate** a person's face, voice, or actions in a video. What was once possible only in expensive film studios can now be done by almost anyone with a laptop and the right software. A **deepfake** can make a politician appear to say something they never said, or place a person in a situation they were never in. The potential for **misinformation** is enormous, and it raises serious **ethical** questions about **consent** and trust in visual media.

Even at a more everyday level, AI is quietly reshaping how we perceive reality. Smartphone camera apps now routinely use AI to smooth skin, brighten eyes, reshape faces, and enhance colours — all before the photo is even saved. Some apps apply these changes automatically, without the user actively choosing to do so. **Augmented reality** filters on social media platforms allow users to transform their appearance entirely in real time. The result is a world in which our **perception** of what people actually look like is increasingly shaped by algorithmic decisions we did not consciously make.

There is also the growing issue of **surveillance**. Facial recognition technology — the same type of AI that helps the Clips camera identify familiar faces — is now used by governments, law enforcement agencies, and private companies to track people in public spaces. In some countries, this technology is embedded in street cameras and public transport systems. Supporters argue it makes cities safer; critics point out that it can be used to monitor and control populations, and that it often produces inaccurate results when used on people from certain ethnic backgrounds — a clear example of algorithmic bias.

So when we ask whether the Google Clips camera is a good idea, we are really asking a much bigger question: who should decide what is worth remembering? A camera that filters out sadness is, in a small way, making that choice for us. And as AI becomes more powerful, the choices it makes on our behalf will only grow larger. If Google's quirky little camera achieves nothing more than making us think carefully about these questions, then its invention will not have been in vain.

ACTIVITIES

1 Read the article and decide if these statements are True (T), False (F), or Not Given (NG).

- 1 The Google Clips camera requires the user to press a button to take a photo.
- 2 The camera tends to avoid photographing people who look sad or bored.
- 3 Google has no plans to change the camera's preference for happy expressions.
- 4 Research suggests that social media content can cause 'Facebook envy'.
- 5 Deepfakes can only be created by professional film studios.
- 6 Facial recognition technology always produces accurate results for all groups.

2 Match the highlighted words and phrases in the article to their meanings.

- 1 not attracting attention; quiet and unnoticeable
- 2 to collect and select the best items from a larger group
- 3 real and genuine; not fake or altered
- 4 to change or influence something in a way that is unfair or dishonest
- 5 media created by AI that realistically shows people doing things they never did
- 6 relating to questions of right and wrong; concerned with moral principles

3 Read the article again and answer these questions in full sentences.

- 1 Why does the Clips camera solve a real problem for parents of young children?
- 2 What does the writer mean by 'brand ambassadors for our own supposedly perfect existence'?
- 3 How does the Clips camera's preference for happy photos reflect a wider human behaviour?
- 4 According to the extension section, what makes deepfakes especially dangerous?
- 5 Why does the writer argue that the Clips camera's invention is not 'in vain'?

4 Discussion: The article raises the question 'Who should decide what is worth remembering?' Write a paragraph (80–100 words) giving your own view.

Consider: Should AI be allowed to make choices about what we photograph?
What are the risks of letting algorithms decide what our memories look like?

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think a camera that only photographs happy moments is a good idea? Why / Why not?

Are you aware of how much AI already edits or filters your photos without you choosing?

How dangerous do you think deepfakes are for society? What can be done about them?

Should facial recognition technology be allowed in public spaces? Where do you draw the line?